

SIZLE

Brand Voice Guide — Implementation Spec

The committed voice for ALL user-facing text · funny friend who has your back

Build instructions · apply across the entire app

INSTRUCTIONS FOR THE BUILD ASSISTANT: This is the committed, final brand voice for Sizzle. Rewrite ALL user-facing copy across the app to follow it — onboarding, empty states, recipe/browse screens, cook-step instructions, doneness gates, waiting screens, failure states, completion screens, premium upsells, achievement names, push notifications, and cook-card text. Use the register map (Section 3) to decide humor vs. warmth at each moment, follow the hard rules (Section 2) without exception, and match the tone of the before/after examples (Section 5). When in doubt, run the copy through the self-check in Section 8. Do not invent new features — only replace and improve the text/copy. Show me the changes before finalizing.

1. The Voice, In One Line

THE FUNNY FRIEND WHO ACTUALLY HAS YOUR BACK.

Irreverent, dry, self-aware humor as the default — PLUS a streak of genuine warmth at the moments that matter. The humor disarms the fear of cooking (if the app's joking, you're allowed to be bad at it). The warmth is the payoff that makes someone come back on the next lonely Wednesday. Comedy gets them in the door; feeling cared for is what makes them stay.

This is Dr. Squatch / Dollar Shave Club energy — selling an 'unsexy' thing to young men through humor that doesn't take itself seriously — but with one upgrade: Dr. Squatch sells soap, which has no emotional moment. Cooking does. Feeding yourself well when you're broke and alone is quietly emotional, so Sizzle's voice can reach a warmth that a soap brand never needed. Use it. Pure jokes would be funny but emotionally flat. The blend is the whole point.

2. The Hard Rules (never break these)

RULE 1 — TEASE THE COOK, NEVER THE COOK-ER. The single most important rule. NEVER insult the user directly. Never make them feel dumb, slow, or bad at this. Punch at the food, the situation, the stereotypes, the pretension, and takeout — never at the person holding the phone. The moment the app makes the user feel stupid, it's lost them. A tired 19-year-old must always feel laughed WITH, never laughed AT.

What this means in practice:

✓ FAIR GAME to roast	✗ NEVER roast
Food snobbery & food snobs	The user directly ('you're bad at this')
Pretentious chef culture / MasterChef energy	The user's skill level in a way that stings

✓ FAIR GAME to roast	✗ NEVER roast
Needlessly complicated recipes (40 ingredients)	The user's intelligence ('it's not that hard, genius')
Recipe blogs with 2,000 words before the recipe	The user's body, looks, or worth
The idea that cooking has to be hard or serious	The user's money situation, meanly
Takeout / DoorDash (the real enemy)	The user's life choices
The food itself ('that steak's putting up a fight')	Anything that makes them feel judged
The situation ('your fridge is looking empty')	Anything mean-spirited, full stop

RULE 2 — INDIRECT / SHARED SELF-DEPRECATION IS OK; DIRECT INSULTS ARE NOT.

Gentle 'we've all been there' humor where the user is IN on the joke is great ('we're as surprised as you are that you're cooking'). The user is a co-conspirator, never the punchline. Light, shared, warm. Never pointed AT them.

RULE 3 — DURING ACTUAL COOKING, CLARITY BEATS COMEDY. In live cook-step instructions and doneness gates, the instruction must be crystal clear FIRST. A beginner needs to understand exactly what to do. Humor is seasoning on top of a clear instruction — it must NEVER make the instruction confusing or bury what to do. If a joke obscures the action, cut the joke. Clarity is safety here.

RULE 4 — FEEL MASCULINE, DON'T ANNOUNCE IT. Never say 'this is for men' or lean on forced 'bro' energy — that reads as cringe to the exact audience you want. Masculinity comes through CONFIDENCE and directness (short, punchy sentences), the bold fire aesthetic, competence framing ('you can cook a perfect steak'), and self-reliance ('don't need takeout'). It should feel like a confident friend, not a beer commercial's idea of what men like. Masculine in tone, never in announcement.

3. The Register Map — When To Be Funny vs. Warm

This is the core decision guide. For each moment in the app, use this register. Most copy is humor with a little warmth underneath; the dial shifts toward warmth at emotional payoff moments.

Moment / screen	Register	Why
Onboarding / welcome	Humor (light)	Disarm fear, set the fun tone
Empty states (no saved recipes etc.)	Humor	Low stakes — be playful
Browse / recipe pick	Humor (confident)	Anti-pretension, 'real food, no nonsense'
Prep / mise en place	Clear + light edge	Clarity first, humor as seasoning
Live cook-step cues	Clear, dry edge	CLARITY WINS — humor must not obscure the action
Doneness gates ('is it done?')	Warm + reassuring	The anxious moment — reassure, never joke at their expense

Moment / screen	Register	Why
Waiting / simmer	Humor	Nothing's happening — entertain them
Failure / burnt cook	Humor on top, WARMTH under	Disarm embarrassment, then have their back
Completion (normal cook)	Warm, dry edge	The payoff — let it land
Completion (comfort food / milestone)	Full warmth	The emotional core — be sincere for a beat
First cook ever	Warm	Encourage — everyone starts here
Premium upsell	Humor (self-aware)	No pressure, in on the joke
Push notifications	Humor + a little warmth	Get them back — don't nag
Achievement names	Humor	Shareable, fun
Marketing / taglines	Humor (confident)	Differentiation

4. The Core Positioning Thread

SIZLE IS WHAT YOU OPEN INSTEAD OF THE TAKEOUT APP. The enemy isn't MasterChef — it's the DoorDash cart at 8pm on a Wednesday. That's the moment Sizle wins: it's late, you're tired, takeout is \$23 for mediocre food, and you actually want something good. Sizle = cheaper, better, and made by you.

THE EMOTIONAL CORE: Comfort food, the stuff that actually satisfies, made by you, when you're broke and tired. The warm register lives here. Weave this Wednesday-night, comfort-food, save-money feeling through the emotional beats — it's the heart under the humor.

The combination to hit constantly: the DIG at takeout (humor) + the WARMTH of feeding yourself well (heart). 'Put down the DoorDash — you can make this for four bucks, and it's better than what you were about to order anyway.' That one line IS the voice: the joke and the care, together.

5. Copy Examples — Match This Tone

Rewrite every touchpoint to match these. They demonstrate the humor-plus-warmth balance and the register shifts. Use them as the pattern.

Onboarding / welcome — [HUMOR]

Don't: Welcome! Let's learn to cook together.

Sizle: You're about to cook a steak to Free Bird. We're as surprised as you are. Let's go.

Light, shared self-deprecation — the user is in on the joke, not the butt of it.

Empty state, no saved recipes — [HUMOR]

Don't: You haven't saved any recipes yet.

Sizle: Nothing saved yet. Kind of like your fridge. Let's fix that.

Roasts the situation (empty fridge), never the user.

Browse / recipe list — [HUMOR, confident]

Don't: *Browse our recipe collection.*

Sizle: Real food. No 40-ingredient nonsense. Pick one.

Punches at needlessly complicated recipes — anti-pretension.

Prep / get ingredients ready — [CLEAR + light]

Sizle: Get your stuff together first. Trust us — it's a lot calmer than scrambling once the pan's hot.

Clarity first (do the prep), warmth/reassurance second. No joke that obscures the instruction.

Live cook cue — [CLEAR, dry edge — CLARITY WINS]

Sizle: Pour the eggs in. Keep the heat low. We're not making rubber here.

The instruction (pour eggs, low heat) is crystal clear; the joke is a tiny garnish that doesn't bury the action.

Doneness gate — [WARM + reassuring]

Don't: *Are the eggs done?*

Sizle: Poke at them. Still a little soft and glossy in the middle? Pull them now — they keep cooking off the heat. You've got this.

The anxious moment. Reassure and guide. NO joke at the user's expense here.

Simmer / waiting — [HUMOR]

Don't: *Please wait while the sauce simmers.*

Sizle: Now we wait. Stir it now and then. Try not to wander off — the pasta has trust issues.

Entertains during dead time. Teases the food, not the cook.

Burnt / failed cook — [HUMOR on top, WARMTH underneath]

Don't: *Your cook was rated poorly.*

Sizle: Alright, that one fought back. Happens to literally everyone — even the people who pretend it doesn't. Run it back. You'll get it.

The KEY blend: a joke to disarm the embarrassment, then genuine 'I've got you' warmth. Never 'you failed.'

Completion, normal cook — [WARM, dry edge]

Don't: *Recipe complete!*

Sizle: That's a real meal. You made it — four bucks and actually good. Beats whatever you were about to order.

The payoff lands. Warmth with the takeout dig. Drop 'look at you, functioning adult' — too close to teasing the user.

Completion, comfort food / Wednesday night — [FULL WARMTH]

Don't: *You finished the recipe.*

Sizle: Comfort food, made by you, on a random Wednesday. Money saved, and it actually tastes like something. That's a good night. Nice work.

The emotional core. Sincere, not sappy. This is the moment the warm register matters most.

First cook ever — [WARM]

Don't: You completed your first recipe.

Sizle: First one down. Everyone starts exactly here. It only gets easier — and better — from here.

Pure encouragement. Lower the barrier, build confidence.

Premium upsell — [HUMOR, self-aware]

Don't: Upgrade to Premium for more features.

Sizle: Want to cook to your own music? That's a Premium thing. We've got bills too. No pressure.

Self-aware and honest about being a business — disarming, never pushy.

Push notification (re-engagement) — [HUMOR + warmth]

Don't: Don't forget to cook today!

Sizle: It's Wednesday. The takeout app is right there, judging you. Or — make something good for four bucks. Your call.

The takeout dig (humor) + the better option (warmth/care). Gets them back without nagging.

Cook card watermark — [HUMOR]

Don't: Made with Sizle.

Sizle: Made with Sizle. Yeah, cooking to music is a thing now. Wild.

Self-aware, shareable.

Achievement names — [HUMOR]:

- **First cook:** "Didn't Order Takeout" (not "First Cook Complete")
- **Cook eggs several times:** "Certified Egg Guy"
- **Nail a medium-rare steak:** "Steak Whisperer"
- **Save \$X worth of takeout:** "The Anti-DoorDash"
- **Cook streak:** "On a Roll" / "Can't Stop Won't Stop"

Marketing taglines — [HUMOR, confident]:

- "Put the phone down. You can make this."
- "Cooking, but make it loud."
- "Better than takeout. Cheaper too."
- "The cooking app that's actually on your side."
- "Steak. Free Bird. Let's go."

6. Voice Mechanics (the how)

- **Short and punchy.** Direct sentences. Fragments are fine. Confidence reads in brevity. No corporate padding, no 'we're thrilled to,' no exclamation-mark enthusiasm.
- **Dry over zany.** Deadpan, understated humor — not wacky or random. The funny is in the dry delivery and the gap between low stakes and confident treatment.
- **Talk TO them like a friend, not AT them like a brand.** Conversational, never earnest or instructional-corporate.
- **A little crude is fine; offensive is not.** Confident and slightly irreverent, never mean, never punching down.
- **Warmth is sincere, not sappy.** When the dial shifts warm, mean it — but keep the dry Sizzle edge. One genuine beat, not a greeting card.
- **Never break Rule 1.** If a line could make the user feel dumb, rewrite it to aim at the food, the situation, or the snobs instead.

7. What To Avoid

- **Forced 'bro' energy** — no 'bruh,' 'let's get this bread,' gym-bro caricature, or beer-commercial masculinity. Feel masculine through confidence, don't perform it.
- **Any joke at the user's expense** — see Rule 1. This is the line that can't be crossed.
- **Humor that buries the instruction** — during a cook, clarity wins. A confused beginner is a lost beginner.
- **All-jokes-no-heart** — if every line is a wisecrack, it reads as trying too hard and never lets the emotional payoff land. Use the warm register at the right moments.
- **Corporate-speak** — no 'seamless experience,' 'elevate your cooking journey,' 'we're excited to announce.' Ever.
- **Cheesy or precious** — the thing Sizzle punches at. Don't become it. No food-blog wistfulness, no 'crafted with love.'

8. Self-Check Before Finalizing Any Copy

Run every rewritten line through these. If any answer is wrong, revise.

1. **Does this insult the USER directly or make them feel dumb?** → If yes, rewrite to aim at the food / situation / snobbery / takeout instead.
2. **Is this a live cooking step?** → If yes, is the instruction crystal clear despite the humor? If the joke obscures the action, cut the joke.
3. **Is this an emotional payoff moment** (completion, comfort food, first cook, milestone)? → If yes, dial UP warmth and dial DOWN jokes.
4. **Does it punch at pretension / takeout / the situation** rather than the person? → It should.
5. **Does it feel masculine through confidence** rather than forced 'bro' energy? → It should.

6. **Would a tired, broke 19-year-old feel laughed WITH, not laughed AT?** → Must be yes, every time.

THE ONE-LINE SUMMARY FOR THE AI: Rewrite all copy as the funny friend who has your back — dry, confident, irreverent humor by default, genuine warmth at the payoff moments (completion, comfort food, first cooks). Punch at food snobbery, pretension, and the takeout cart — NEVER at the user. Keep cooking instructions crystal clear. Feel masculine through confidence, never by announcing it. The voice is the joke and the care, together.